Lesson 04: The Writing Process

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 2 The Writing Process.

In this lesson

You will follow one paragraph assignment from the first idea to the final copy through the three stages of the writing process: pre-writing, writing and post-writing. You will practise narrowing down topics, sorting ideas, and revising and editing a student's draft. These steps will make all your assignments, including your psychology papers, better organized and more accurate.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the three stages of the writing process and the steps in each stage.
- Understand an assignment, narrow down a broad topic and brainstorm ideas.
- Make a paragraph outline with a full topic sentence and supporting ideas in words and phrases.
- Revise, edit and proofread a draft with the Self Checklist.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
brainstorm	write down ideas as quickly as you can for two to ten minutes	free writing, making a list, mind mapping
narrow down	make a broad topic more specific	technology → computer technology → computer technology for college students
outline	a simple plan of a paragraph: the topic sentence as a full sentence, the support in words and phrases	It may take five to ten minutes to make an outline.
draft	the first copy of a complete paragraph, based on the outline	Write a draft of the paragraph.
revise	improve the ideas and the organization	Revise the organization for unity, cohesion, and completion.
edit	correct the grammar and sentence structure	Edit grammar and sentence structure.
proofread	read the paragraph from beginning to end at least one more time to catch missed errors	Make a new copy, proofread, save, and submit.
es·SEN·tial	extremely important, cannot live without	What is essential in baking the perfect bread?

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
CRU·cial	very important	Understanding the requirements is crucial.
en·SURE	make sure, to be certain	The stages and steps ensure the good quality of your paragraph.
SEEM·ing·ly	in appearance but may not be true	Do not pick a seemingly "easy" topic.
es·TAB·lish	build, set up	Think of this as establishing a good habit.

Rules and explanations

The three stages

If you miss or reverse one step when you bake bread, the bread fails. Writing is the same: it follows a step-by-step order called the writing process.

Stage	Steps
1. Pre-writing: get ideas and make an outline	Understand the assignment. Choose your topic and narrow it down if necessary; brainstorm by free writing, listing, or mind mapping. Decide on the main idea and make an outline.
2. Writing: write the ideas into a paragraph	Write the ideas into sentences based on the outline. Include the basic parts: title, topic sentence, supporting sentences with details, transitions, concluding sentence.
3. Post-writing: revise, edit, proofread, and submit	Revise the ideas and the organization (unity, cohesion, completion). Edit the grammar. Check format, spelling, punctuation and capitalization. Make a new copy, proofread, save and submit.

Stage 1 in detail

Understand the assignment. Ask seven questions: Purpose? How? Who reads? Final product? Format? Due? Where? See the book's example table in section IV.

Choose and narrow your topic.

- Do: write from your heart. Ask: Am I interested in this topic? How much do I know about it? Do I have an experience or perspective that most classmates might not have?
- Do not: pick a seemingly "easy" topic that you know little about, or choose a topic because the Internet has a lot of information on it.

Brainstorm. Write as fast as you can. Do not worry about grammar, spelling or punctuation, and do not judge your ideas. Read the book's three examples: free writing, a list and a mind map.

Make an outline. Decide on the main idea, and keep or throw out ideas.

- Write the topic sentence as a **complete sentence** at the top.
- Write the supporting ideas and details in **words and phrases** (symbols such as # and $ are fine), not complete sentences. Then you can easily spot an idea that does not support the topic sentence.

- A new idea while you write? Put it in the outline first and ask: Does it support my topic sentence? Which part does it belong to? Is there already a similar idea?
- The title is often written last.

Stages 2 and 3

The draft is the first complete copy, written from the outline. Mistakes are normal at this stage.

Post-writing has four steps:

1. Revise the ideas and organization: add examples and transitions, delete irrelevant sentences, add any missing title or concluding sentence.
2. Edit grammar and sentence structure.
3. Check format, spelling, punctuation and capitalization. Do step 2 before step 3.
4. Go through the Self Checklist (see the Writing task). Then make a new copy, **proofread** it, save it and submit it.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so check capitals carefully in Stage 3: sentence beginnings, the pronoun "I", and names ("i" and "english" in the book's draft are errors). - In Arabic the subject pronoun is often left out because the verb shows the person. English needs a subject in every sentence: "Can let my thoughts flow" → "I can let my thoughts flow".

Practice

Exercise 1. The writing process. Answer in full sentences.

1. What is the writing process? Why is it important?
2. What are the three stages in the process? What are the steps in each stage?

Exercise 2. Narrowing down. The book's examples (in pictures, not printed in your material): technology → computer technology → computer technology for college students; technology → wireless audio equipment → wireless ear buds (my birthday gift). Narrow down each topic in two steps, from your own experience:

1. vacations
2. high school memories
3. social media
4. online classes

Exercise 3. Sorting ideas. Main idea: *Jerry's Burgers is my favorite lunch place*. Put the ideas into three categories: Food, Services, Facilities. If an idea does not fit the main idea, cross it out. Examples: Food: fresh ingredients; Services: fast service; Facilities: meeting room.

nice decorations, clean washrooms, beautiful paintings on walls, Asian and Middle Eastern flavors, noisy, not many salad choices, expensive, smiling owner, no place for kids to play, free soda, no parking, tasty soup bowls, kids' menu, low fat menu, vegetarian choices, background music too loud, gluten-free options, polite wait staff, no delivery

Revising practice (the book's example draft). Read "Example: Paragraph draft" (section V of the lesson material) before you look at section VI. Answer:

1. Does the draft have a title?
2. Which sentence does not support the topic sentence?
3. After "people often do not understand me, or they say I am wrong", what is missing?
4. What is missing before "i am learning to think faster and more natural with the help in NSNT"?
5. What details are missing after "write from 5 minutes to 10 minutes daily"?
6. Does the draft have a concluding sentence?

Editing practice (the book's example draft). Correct the errors in these sentences from the student's paragraph. Each one has one to three errors in grammar, sentence structure, punctuation, capitalization or spelling.

1. The reasons why I like NSNT (title)
2. My teacher introduce it in the beginning of the semester.
3. Students writes on a topic nonstop for at least 5 minute.
4. First, the strategy helps me learn to express my self correctly with english.
5. i been in the U.S. for only one year.
6. However; people often do not understand me, or they say I am wrong.
7. When I translate it into english. My sentence becomes "Is a day beautiful."
8. Second, i am learning to think faster and more natural with the help in NSNT.
9. Though, I felt very uncomfortable in the beginning now after two months of training, I starting to feel that my ideas flow more easy in English.
10. Because my teacher do not grade my work based on accuracy. Can let my thoughts flow freely on paper without worrying about my grade.

More items: compare the draft in section V with the final copy in section VI and find the other errors. Your tutor can check them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me a short writing assignment from a psychology course. I will answer the seven 'Understand the assignment' questions. Tell me what I missed."
- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Is the topic sentence a complete sentence? Are the supporting ideas in words and phrases, and do they all support the topic sentence?"
- "Here is my draft: [paste]. First comment only on ideas and organization. After I revise, check grammar and sentence structure, then format, spelling, punctuation and capitalization."

Writing task

Exercise 4 in the book: from brainstorming to paragraph. Choose three of these topics: driving in the U.S. (or in your country); my first class at college; the neighborhood where I grew up; the

person I admire the most; a childhood memory; a disappointing holiday; advantages or disadvantages of cell phones; characteristics of a good shopping mall.

1. Brainstorm each topic in a different way: free writing (NSNT style), a list, a mind map. Narrow down the topic if necessary.
2. Write an outline for each topic: the topic sentence as a full sentence, the supporting ideas and details in words and phrases.
3. Choose one outline and write a paragraph of about 200 words with a title, a topic sentence, 3 supporting ideas with details, transitions and a concluding sentence.
4. Format: typed, double spaced, font size 12, 1-inch margins, first line indented; your name, class and date at the upper right.

Self Checklist (from the book)

- Is my paragraph clear to understand and interesting to read?
- Did I include a topic sentence with a clear topic and a controlling idea?
- Did I include 3 supporting ideas with details, transitions and a concluding sentence?
- Did I try my best to use correct sentence structure, verbs, and other grammar aspects?
- Did I try my best to have correct spelling, punctuation, and capitalization?
- Did I follow the proper paragraph format?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. It is the step-by-step order for writing: three major stages, each with smaller steps. The right steps ensure a well organized, focused and accurate paragraph; if you skip steps, you may need more time to redo the work later.
2. Stage 1, pre-writing: understand the assignment; choose, narrow down and brainstorm a topic; make an outline. Stage 2, writing: write a draft from the outline. Stage 3, post-writing: revise ideas and organization; edit grammar; check format, spelling, punctuation and capitalization; make a new copy, proofread, save and submit.

Exercise 2 (example answers; yours will be different)

1. vacations → vacations with my family → a surprise trip to the mountains with my brothers
2. high school memories → my high school teachers → the chemistry teacher who made me love science
3. social media → social media for students → using a class chat group to prepare for exams
4. online classes → my first online class → what I learned in my first online psychology class

Exercise 3

- Food: fresh ingredients, Asian and Middle Eastern flavors, tasty soup bowls, kids' menu, low fat menu, vegetarian choices, gluten-free options, free soda
- Services: fast service, smiling owner, polite wait staff (free soda and kids' menu can also go here)
- Facilities: meeting room, nice decorations, clean washrooms, beautiful paintings on walls
- Cross out (negative points, so they do not explain why it is your favorite place): noisy, not many salad choices, expensive, no place for kids to play, no parking, background music too loud, no delivery

Revising practice (book: the comments in section VI)

1. No. The book adds the title "The Reasons Why I Like NSNT".
2. "The discussions we have in reading classes also help me think in English because my classmates cannot wait for me to translate from Spanish." (It is about reading classes, not NSNT.)
3. An example. The book adds the Spanish sentence "Es un dia bonito" and its wrong translation "Is a day beautiful."
4. A transition: "Second,".
5. Examples of what the writer writes about: childhood memories, current events, and school activities.
6. No. The book adds: "The NSNT is one of the best approaches in helping me think and use English. I will definitely keep practicing this strategy."

Editing practice (book: the corrections in section VI)

1. The Reasons Why I Like NSNT

2. My teacher **introduced** it in the beginning of the semester.
3. Students **write** on a topic nonstop for at least 5 **minutes**. (The final copy says "Students **should write**".)
4. First, the strategy helps me learn to express **myself** correctly with **English**.
5. **I have been** in the U.S. for only one year.
6. However**,** people often do not understand me, or they say I am wrong.
7. When I translate it into **English, my** sentence becomes "Is a day beautiful."
8. Second, **I** am learning to think faster and more **naturally** with the help in NSNT.
9. Though I felt very uncomfortable in the **beginning,** now after two months of training, I **have started** to feel that my ideas flow more **easily** in English. (The final copy has "I **am starting**", which is also correct.)
10. Because my teacher **does** not grade my work based on **accuracy, I can** let my thoughts flow freely on paper without worrying about my grade.

My notes